THE SCAR THAT SKIPPED A GENERATION

A grandparent carries a smallpox vaccination scar. The grandchild beside them never needed one.

Production guide and copy-ready brief · real footage shot on a phone, no AI · 56 seconds (hard limit 59) · vertical 9:16 · one grandparent, one grandchild, one room

The idea in one line. Two arms side by side. The older arm carries the round scar of the smallpox vaccine. The younger one has none, because smallpox was declared eradicated in 1980 and the vaccine stopped. The grandparent tells us, in their own words, what it was like. Then the child asks the question the film turns on: "What will I have that my kids won't need?" Three fact cards answer it, and the end card says SOME THINGS SHOULD SKIP A GENERATION.

Deadline check. The prize page says 11:59 PM local time on 1 November 2026. Check on the page whose local time that means before planning the shoot. At 19:30 UTC on 1 November it was already past midnight in Pakistan. If the deadline is Pacific time (Foresight Institute is in San Francisco), it falls at 12:59 PM on Monday 2 November in Pakistan. Section 11 plans a morning shoot for that case.

1. Copy-ready quick brief (paste this to the team)

Make THE SCAR THAT SKIPPED A GENERATION, a 56-second real-footage video (hard limit 59), vertical 9:16, shot on a phone by a window. Cast: one grandparent who has a smallpox vaccination scar ("chechak ka teeka") on the upper arm, and one grandchild. Shoot five things: a close-up of the scar, the reveal of both of them side by side, the grandparent talking unscripted about the vaccine, the hero shot of the two arms side by side with the child touching the scar, and the child asking "What will I have that my kids won't need?" In the edit, add the stamp SMALLPOX: ERADICATED 1980, three fact cards and the end card, all word for word from section 5. Before filming: confirm the scar is smallpox and not BCG, film the child's clear arm, and get written consent (section 2). The child appears only as arms, hands and voice unless a parent agrees in writing. Captions are burned in, large, and work with the sound off. No AI, no filters, no commercial music. Do not post without the project owner's and the family's OK.

2. Three checks before anyone presses record (pass-fail)

Check	Why it matters	How to pass
The scar is smallpox, not BCG	In Pakistan almost everyone also carries a BCG (TB vaccine) scar from birth, and the two are easy to confuse. A wrong scar breaks the whole film.	A smallpox scar is usually a sunken round or slightly irregular pit, about 6–12 mm across, left by many quick jabs in childhood before about 1980. A BCG scar is often smaller and raised. Ask the grandparent: "Yeh chechak ka teeka hai?" If they are not sure, ask a doctor or film a different elder. Never guess.
The child's arm is clear	The child almost certainly has a BCG scar on one arm. If it shows in the hero shot, the picture says the opposite of the film.	Check both of the child's upper arms and film the clear one. Seat them so the grandparent's scarred arm and the child's clear arm meet in the middle of the frame. If the scar is on the grandparent's left arm and the child's right arm is clear, the grandparent sits on the left of the frame and the child on the right.

Check	Why it matters	How to pass
Consent	Real people, a child, and a public post that stays up for months.	Get written consent from the grandparent and from the child's parent or guardian. Before they sign, show them what the video is, that it will be posted publicly on social media for the prize, and that it stays public. The child appears only as arms, hands and voice, unless the parent agrees in writing to show the face. No full names, school uniforms, house numbers or location tags. Anyone can stop the shoot at any time.

3. What is true, and what goes on screen

Thread	The fact	On screen
Smallpox	WHO certified eradication on 9 December 1979. The World Health Assembly declared it on 8 May 1980 and recommended that all countries stop routine vaccination.	SMALLPOX: ERADICATED 1980 (small: WHO)
Who has the scar	Vaccination stopped at different times: in 1972 in the US, around 1980 in most other countries. And not everyone was vaccinated.	MANY PEOPLE OVER 50 HAVE THIS SCAR. (Not "most people born before the late 1970s", which cannot be checked.)
Polio	Wild polio is now endemic in only two countries, Pakistan and Afghanistan.	WILD POLIO: LEFT IN JUST 2 COUNTRIES. This is the card closest to home.
Malaria	WHO recommended the first malaria vaccine (RTS,S) in October 2021 and a second (R21/Matrix-M) on 2 October 2023.	MALARIA: 2 WHO-RECOMMENDED VACCINES (2021, 2023). Say "recommended", not "approved".
Guinea worm	More than 3.5 million human cases a year in 1986; 10 in 2025, provisional (The Carter Center).	GUINEA WORM: 3.5 MILLION CASES A YEAR (1986) → 10 (2025). Not "14 (2023)", which is out of date.
Memories	A grandparent's memory is true as a memory.	Keep "I remember..." lines. Cut any number or medical claim you cannot check.

4. The film feel

Element	Standard
Tone	Warm and funny. A family moment, not a lecture: real people, real skin, real laughter.
Format	Vertical 9:16, 1080×1920, 25 fps, shot on a phone. No AI, no beauty filter, no skin smoothing.
Camera	The phone on a tripod or a stack of books at eye level for the interview. Handheld but slow for the close-ups and the reveal. Use the 1x lens for the two-shot, and the 2x or 3x lens from 30–50 cm for the scar, never the wide lens up close.
Light	One big window to the side, with the ceiling lights off. Turn the arm so the window light skims across the scar; that is what shows its texture.

Element	Standard
Sound	The grandparent's real voice is the film. Fans, AC and TV off; phones on silent. A second phone records a voice note 30–40 cm from the grandparent, out of frame, or use a clip-on mic. Clap once at the start of each take so the sound can be synced.
Music	None, or one soft piano track you have the rights to, 10 dB under the voice. No commercial songs.
Captions	Burned in, large, and readable with the sound off. English subtitles for any Urdu or Punjabi.
Pace	Calm. Hold the two-arms shot for at least 6 seconds; it is the film.

5. Script (56 s; hard limit 59)

IN	OUT	Picture	On screen (word for word)	Sound
0.0	3.0	Extreme close-up of the scar in window light. The grandparent's fingertip traces it.	MANY PEOPLE OVER 50 HAVE THIS SCAR.	Room tone; one piano note
3.0	6.0	Pull back, or cut, to both of them side by side, the child's arm next to the scarred arm.	THEIR GRANDCHILDREN DON'T.	
6.0	18.0	The grandparent explains in their own words what the teeka was, who gave it, how it felt and why everyone got one. Two or three short bites. Optional cutaway to an old family photo or vaccination certificate.	English subtitles	Their voice only
18.0	21.5	A red rubber stamp slams onto the frame.	SMALLPOX: ERADICATED 1980 (small: WHO)	One hard thunk
21.5	31.0	THE KEY SHOT: the old arm and the young arm side by side. The child's finger touches the scar. Hold.	(no text)	Natural sound; a small laugh is perfect
31.0	34.0	The child asks, as a voice with hands in frame, or on camera if a parent agreed in writing.	"WHAT WILL I HAVE THAT MY KIDS WON'T NEED?"	The child's voice
34.0	38.0	Card 1, over soft footage of hands.	WILD POLIO: LEFT IN JUST 2 COUNTRIES (small: WHO)	A soft tick
38.0	42.0	Card 2, over the grandparent smiling.	MALARIA: 2 WHO-RECOMMENDED VACCINES (2021, 2023)	A soft tick
42.0	46.0	Card 3, over the two arms.	GUINEA WORM: 3.5 MILLION CASES A YEAR (1986) → 10 (2025) (small: The Carter Center)	A soft tick
46.0	52.0	The grandparent's reaction to the question: a laugh, a hand on the child's head, a blessing.	Subtitles if they speak	Natural sound
52.0	56.0	End card over the two-arms shot, darkened.	SOME THINGS SHOULD SKIP A GENERATION.	Music resolves, then silence

The child's line. Let the child say it in their own words, in Urdu or English, for example "Mere bachon ko kaun sa teeka nahin lagwana parega?" ("Which vaccine won't my kids need?"). The subtitle can keep the English line above if the meaning matches.

6. Shot list

#	Shot	How	Notes
1	Scar close-up	2x or 3x lens, 30–50 cm away, window light skimming across the scar. Three takes: still, a slow push-in, the fingertip tracing it.	The opening, and the backup thumbnail.
2	The reveal	Start on the scar and slowly pull the phone back to the two-shot, or shoot it as two cuts. Two takes.	Keep the child's face out of frame unless a parent agreed in writing.
3	Interview	Grandparent in a medium close-up at eye level, looking at the child or at the interviewer beside the lens, not into it. Keep rolling for 5–10 minutes.	Questions in section 7. Fresh energy, so shoot it first.
4	Two arms (hero)	Both sleeves up, arms resting side by side on a table or on their knees; frame only the arms. The child's finger touches the scar. At least five takes.	This is the thumbnail. Clear arm next to the scarred arm (section 2).
5	The child's question	Several natural takes, with the sound recorded close.	Do not over-rehearse; slight hesitation is good.
6	Reaction	The grandparent's face as the question lands. Roll before and after.	Often the best moment of the day.
7	Hands	The grandparent's hand over the child's; hands with tea; hands resting.	Footage to run under the cards.
8	Archive (optional)	An old family photo, or an old vaccination certificate if the family kept one.	Only real items the family owns.
9	Polio finger mark (optional)	Only if the child really has a fresh ink mark from a recent polio campaign: a close-up of the finger.	The perfect echo of the scar. Never mark a finger for the shot.
10	Room tone	20 seconds of the room in silence, with everyone still.	Lets the editor smooth the cuts.

7. Interview guide

- Sit beside the phone, so the grandparent looks just off the lens. Ask one question at a time, then wait. Silence brings the best answers.
- Ask them to answer in full sentences ("This mark is from..."), so each answer makes sense on its own.
- Let them speak Urdu, Punjabi or English, whatever is natural. Subtitles do the rest.
- Never correct them on camera. If a fact is wrong, leave that bit out in the edit.
- Questions: "Yeh nishan kis cheez ka hai?" (What is this mark from?) · "Yeh teeka aap ko kab laga tha? Kitne saal ke thay?" (When did you get it? How old were you?) · "Kaisa laga tha? Dard hua tha?" (What did it feel like? Did it hurt?) · "Kaun lagata tha: school mein, ya ghar aa kar?" (Who gave it: at school, or at home?) · "Chechak ke baare mein aap ko kya yaad hai? Log kitna darte thay?" (What do you remember about smallpox? How scared were people?) · "Aap ke pote ya nawase ko yeh teeka kyun nahin laga?" (Why doesn't your grandchild have it?) · "Aap ke khayal mein agli kaun si bimari khatam hogi?" (Which disease do you think ends next?)
- Then let the child ask their question, and keep rolling on the grandparent's face.

8. Phone settings

- Vertical, 1080p or 4K, 25 fps. On Pakistan's 50 Hz power, 25 or 50 fps avoids flicker from lights.

- Lock exposure and focus: long-press on the subject (iPhone: AE/AF lock; Android: Pro mode). Turn off beauty mode, portrait blur and any filter.
- Clean the lens. Fill the frame with the 2x or 3x lens instead of moving the phone closer.
- Airplane mode on the camera phone so a call cannot cut a take. Check storage and battery first.
- Do a 10-second test take with sound, and play it back on headphones before the real takes.

9. Edit guide

- Edit in CapCut, InShot or VN (all free) at 1080×1920, 25 fps. Or send the raw clips to Claude, who can cut, caption and mix them.
- The overlays are ready-made in briefs/scar_overlays/png: the two opening lines, the stamp, the child's question, the three fact cards, the end card and the thumbnail text, as ten transparent 1080×1920 PNGs. Each is word for word from section 5 and already placed inside the safe area. Lay each one over the full frame at its time in section 5. Use 00_safe_zone_guide for checking only, and never export it.
- Cut the interview down to about 12 seconds of the best lines. Keep the laughs.
- Captions: a bold sans font in white with a black outline, or on a 60% black box. Two lines at most, about 32 characters a line. Keep all text out of the top 250 px and the bottom 420 px, where the platform buttons sit, and away from the right edge.
- The stamp: red, rotated about 8 degrees, with a two-frame scale-down "slam" and one thunk. Hold each card for at least 3.5 seconds, with a small source line under it.
- Sound: keep the speech clear and steady and the music 10 dB under it. Target about −14 LUFS if your editor can measure loudness.
- Colour: natural and warm. No skin smoothing: the scar's texture is the point.
- Export at 1080×1920, 25 fps, H.264, the highest quality setting. Check it on a phone with the sound off, and check it runs under 59 seconds.

10. Thumbnail, title and caption

Item	Use
Thumbnail	The two-arms frame, with SKIPPED A GENERATION in large type across the empty space.
Title	The Scar That Skipped a Generation
Caption (draft)	My [Nani / Dada] has a scar on her arm from the smallpox vaccine. My [cousin / daughter] doesn't have one, and doesn't need one. Smallpox was declared eradicated in 1980, so the vaccine stopped and the scar skipped a generation. Wild polio is now down to two countries, Pakistan and Afghanistan. Malaria has two WHO-recommended vaccines. Guinea worm fell from 3.5 million cases a year in 1986 to 10 in 2025. Some things should skip a generation. #xhopememeprize

11. Plan for the shoot day

This plan assumes the deadline is 11:59 PM Pacific on 1 November, which is 12:59 PM on Monday 2 November in Pakistan. Confirm it on the prize page first.

Time (Pakistan)	Task
08:00–08:30	Consent forms signed. Check the scar (smallpox, not BCG) and the child's clear arm. Set up by the window, set the phone, and do a 10-second test with sound.

Time (Pakistan)	Task
08:30–09:15	Shoot in this order: the interview, the two-arms hero shot, the scar close-ups and the reveal, the child's question, the reactions, the hands, and the room tone.
09:15–11:00	Edit: assemble the cut, then add captions, the stamp and cards, and the sound, and export.
11:00–11:30	Watch it on a phone with the sound off. Check every card word for word against section 3. Get the grandparent's and the parent's OK to post.
11:30–12:15	Post it publicly and register the entry on the prize page with the link. Keep the post public.

12. Reject on sight

- A BCG scar presented as smallpox, or a child's arm that also shows a scar in the hero shot.
- A child's face without a parent's written consent; names, a school, an address or a location on screen.
- Any card that is not in section 5, or a number changed from section 3.
- Commercial music, filters, skin smoothing, or any AI-made or AI-altered shot. The point is that it is real.
- Running over 59 seconds; captions too small, or covered by platform buttons.
- Needles, illness or fear shown graphically. Keep it warm.

13. Sources

- Smallpox eradication: WHO, who.int/health-topics/smallpox; WHO certification on 9 December 1979 and the World Health Assembly declaration on 8 May 1980, which recommended ending routine vaccination.
- Smallpox and BCG scars: Healthline, healthline.com/health/smallpox-vaccine-scar; UCSF Global Health Sciences, "That scar you have on your arm is probably from a BCG vaccine", globalhealthsciences.ucsf.edu/?p=3970.
- Malaria vaccines: Gavi, "A great day for science: WHO recommends second vaccine against malaria", gavi.org/vaccineswork/great-day-science-who-recommends-second-vaccine-against-malaria.
- Guinea worm: The Carter Center, "10 Guinea Worm Cases Reported Last Year, Lowest on Record", cartercenter.org/?p=25301.
- Wild polio in two countries: WHO, statement of the 43rd Polio IHR Emergency Committee, 11 November 2025, who.int/news/item/11-11-2025-statement-of-the-forty-third-meeting-of-the-polio-ihr-emergency-committee.
- Polio finger marking in Pakistan: The National, thenationalnews.com/world/asia/2021/10/23/polio-vaccination-campaigns-in-pakistan-in-pictures.